

CHRISTIAN VALENCIA

Email: valencic@nber.org

1050 Massachusetts Ave, Cambridge MA 02138

Website: <https://valenciac.github.io>

ACADEMIC POSITIONS

Postdoctoral Fellow, National Bureau of Economic Research (NBER), 2026-2027

EDUCATION

Ph.D. in Agricultural and Applied Economics
University of Illinois at Urbana-Champaign, 2026

M.A. in Economics
Universidad de San Andrés-Argentina, 2019

B.A. in Economics
Universidad Católica Boliviana, 2012

WORKING PAPERS

Visa Regulations, Agricultural Employment, and Productivity (Job Market Paper)
[\[link\]](#)

The H-2A visa program provides US farms access to foreign seasonal labor but requires employers to pay a federally mandated minimum hourly wage, the Adverse Effect Wage Rate, to both foreign and domestic workers performing comparable tasks. This paper studies how increases in the H-2A visa wage affect farms' allocation of agricultural inputs. Using county-level data from the 2002–2022 USDA Census of Agriculture and a border-county pair design that compares counties across state lines, I show that higher visa wages lead farms to substitute away from labor and toward capital and materials. I find that a 1% increase in the visa wage on average leads to a 1.2% increase in machinery values, increases intermediate input use by 3.9% on the intensive margin, and expands the range of inputs used by 1.1% on the extensive margin. I find no effect on employment or payrolls. The results are consistent with labor-cost-driven mechanization and input intensification, which together contribute to higher agricultural productivity.

Soft Skills and Hiring Discrimination (with Sarah Janzen, Yashodhan Ghorpade and Amanina Abdur Rahman) [\[link\]](#). *Submitted*

Hiring discrimination remains widespread, raising questions about how disadvantaged workers can improve labor market outcomes. We examine if employers value soft skills and whether such skills mitigate discrimination. Using a correspondence study in Malaysia, we test the effects of two soft skill signals: leadership and teamwork. We find Malay and Indian names are 11-14 percentage points less likely to be contacted, compared to Chinese names. Signaling teamwork skills reduces discrimination by 34-43%. We

present a model that uses signals to distinguish statistical from taste-based discrimination. Our results are consistent with statistical discrimination, and suggest soft skills can counteract hiring discrimination.

PUBLICATIONS

Peer pressure: Experimental Evidence from Restroom Behavior (with B. Cardinale Lagomarsino, M. Gutman, L. Freira, M. Lanzalet, M. Lauletta, L. Malchik, F. Montano Campos, B. Pacini and M. Rossi). *Economic Inquiry*. Vol 55 (3), 2017. [\[link\]](#)

RESEARCH EXPERIENCE

University of Illinois at Urbana-Champaign, Department of Agricultural and Consumer Economics

- Research Assistant for Professor Nicholas Paulson, Summer 2025
- Research Assistant for Professor Sarah Janzen, Summer 2024
- Research Assistant for Professor Marieke Kleemans, Summer 2020 - Spring 2022

The World Bank, Social Protection and Labor

- Short-Term Consultant, Summer 2022-Spring 2023

WORK EXPERIENCE

CAF Development Bank of Latin America, Buenos Aires - Argentina
Research Officer Aug 2017 - Jun 2019

Ministry of Production, Buenos Aires - Argentina
Technical Advisor, Feb 2016 - Jul 2017

Banco Mercantil Santa Cruz, La Paz - Bolivia
Product Analyst, Apr 2014 - Feb 2015

Institute for Advanced Development Studies, La Paz - Bolivia
Junior Researcher, Jun 2013 - Nov 2013

Aru Foundation, La Paz - Bolivia
Research Assistant, Nov 2011 - Feb 2013

TEACHING EXPERIENCE

University of Illinois at Urbana-Champaign

Instructor:

- Behavioral Economics and Financial Decision Making. Fall 2025

Teaching Assistant:

- Intermediate Applied Microeconomics. Spring 2026
- Behavioral Economics and Financial Decision Making. Spring 2025
- Global Agribusiness Management. Spring 2025

- Environmental Justice and Food Security. Fall 2024
- Applied Statistics Methods and Data Analytics. Spring 2024
- Big Data Analytics in Finance. Fall 2023
- Environmental Economics. Fall 2022 – Spring 2023
- Intermediate Microeconomic Theory. Fall 2020 – Spring 2021

Universidad de San Andrés:

Teaching Assistant:

- Introductory Economics. Fall 2016 - Fall 2018
- Labor Economics. Spring 2016

Universidad Católica Boliviana:

Teaching Assistant:

- Microeconomic Theory. Spring 2010

OUTREACH ARTICLES

- Valencia, C. and N. Paulson. "The Growing Role of H-2A Workers in U.S. Agriculture." *farmdoc daily* (15):125, Department of Agricultural and Consumer Economics, University of Illinois at Urbana-Champaign, July 9, 2025. [\[link\]](#)
- Valencia, C. and N. Paulson. "The role of H-2A Workers in Illinois." *farmdoc daily* (15):129, Department of Agricultural and Consumer Economics, University of Illinois at Urbana-Champaign, July 16, 2025. [\[link\]](#)

PRESENTATIONS

2026: AAEA Annual Meeting

2025: Midwest International Economic Development Conference, Bogotá Experimental Economics Conference, Illinois Economics Association

2024: World Bank Global Solutions Group - Skills Seminar, Illinois Economics Association

GRANTS

2015: Partnership for Economic Policy \$22,000. Evidence on the impacts of Minimum Wage on Labor Market Outcomes: The case of Bolivia (with Marcelo Claure, Alejandra Leyton and Vanessa Sanchez)

SERVICE

2025: Reviewer for the Midwest International Economic Development Conference

2023-2024: International Policy and Development Seminar Graduate Student Coordinator

COMPUTER SKILLS

Python, R, Stata, SQL, LaTeX, QGIS

LANGUAGES

Spanish (Native), English (Fluent), Portuguese (Fluent)

REFERENCES

Sarah Janzen

Associate Professor
Department of Agricultural and Consumer Economics
University of Illinois at Urbana Champaign
sjanzen@illinois.edu

Marieke Kleemans

Professor
Utrecht School of Economics
Utrecht University
m.kleemans@uu.nl

Nicholas Paulson

Professor
Department of Agricultural and Consumer Economics
University of Illinois at Urbana Champaign
npaulson@illinois.edu